

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1996-04-22

To an individual believer

1 your email message . . . has been received at the bahá'í world center,
2 question regarding teaching the faith. . . .
3 in his writings, bahá'u'lláh states clearly the essential requisites for our
4 spiritual growth, and these are reiterated and amplified by 'Abdu'l-bahá in
5 his talks and Tablets. They can be summarized briefly as prayer and medi-
6 tation, the endeavor to conform one's behavior to the exalted standard set
7 224-3. IgANz, p. 138.
8 224-4. mbw , p. 111.224.13
225 1
225 2
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227 forth in the bahá'í Teachings, participation in the life of the bahá'í com-
228 munity, teaching the faith and contributing to the bahá'í fund. different
229 individuals, according to their natures, will follow these paths in varying
230 ways, but all are essential to spiritual growth. The house of justice points
231 out that there can be no rigid formula on how to attain the right balance in our
approach to spirituality, and that the best course here, as in so many
232 things, is to follow the example of 'Abdu'l-bahá.
233 regarding, in particular, teaching the cause of god, from a letter writ-
234 ten on behalf of the beloved guardian, we are reminded that it is a sacred
235 obligation enjoined upon every believer.
236 bahá'u'lláh has enjoined upon the bahá'ís the sacred obligation of teach-
237 ing. we have no priests, therefore the service once rendered by priests to
238 their religions is the service every single bahá'í is expected to render in-
239 dividually to his religion. he must be the one who enlightens new souls,

240 confirms them, heals the wounded and the weary upon the road of life, and
241 gives them to quaff from the chalice of everlasting life—the knowledge of the m
anifestation of g od in h is day.

242 further, bahá'u'lláh exhorts us to “Teach thou the cause of god with an
243 utterance which will cause the bushes to be enkindled, and the call ‘ verily,

there is no god but me, the Almighty, the unconstrained’ to be raised

therefrom.”

244 while living the bahá'í life, good works and service to our fellow men are
245 important aspects in exemplifying and promoting the faith, ‘Abdu'l-b ahá
246 emphasizes that these alone are not sufficient. h e states:

it is at such times that the friends of god avail themselves of the

247 occasion, seize the opportunity, rush forth and win the prize. if their

task is to be confined to good conduct and advice, nothing will be

accomplished. They must speak out, expound the proofs, set forth

248 clear arguments, draw irrefutable conclusions establishing the truth of the
manifestation of the Sun of r eality.

249 225-1

The relevant guidance provided in messages and letters from the house

250 of justice can best be understood in light of the knowledge that teach-

251 ing the faith is each individual’s sacred duty, prescribed by god, and is

252 225-1. Sw Ab, no. 212.225.3

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225 6a

226 m eS Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

227 52fundamental for the advancement of the cause and our own spiritual prog-

228 ress. in its 1995 riṣván message, the house of justice wrote, “f or to teach,

229 bahá'u'lláh himself affirms, is to do the ‘most meritorious of all deeds.’”

230 in another riṣván message, teaching is described as “the food of the spirit

231 . . . it ensures the victory of the covenant and brings those who give their

232 lives to it the supernal happiness of attainment to the good pleasure of their
 233 lord."225-2 The emphasis on teaching which you perceive in these messages
 234 in no way diminishes the importance of the other requisites for spiritual growth, but
 rather should inspire the believers to submerge themselves yet
 235 deeper in prayer, meditation and study of the word of god, and to strive
 236 more vigilantly to live the bahá'í life and to be of service to their fellow man,
 237 as essential requirements to fulfilling their obligation to teach the faith.
 238 regarding the distinctive roles of the institutions of the faith and the
 239 individual believers in the spread of the cause of bahá'u'lláh, in the trans-
 240 formation of the individual and collective lives of peoples and the eventual
 establishment of the kingdom of god on earth, they are described by the
 241 house of justice as follows:

**Though the institutions of the faith are responsible for planning the
 goals and activities of the cause, for stimulating and encouraging**

242 the believers to arise, and for supporting and unifying them in their services, it is, in
 the final analysis, through the spiritual decisions and actions of the individual believers that
 the faith moves forward on its

243 course to ultimate victory.

244 225-3

245 you ask what you should do if you feel the institutions are not functioning
 246 according to the Sacred writings. you will find it helpful in this respect
 247 to deepen your understanding of the writings of bahá'u'lláh and 'Abdu'l-
 248 bahá on the subject of the covenant, possibly by arranging to study with a
 249 believer who is clearly knowledgeable in the faith. To question the actions
 250 or directions of a bahá'í institution certainly does not in itself constitute a
 251 violation of the covenant. one of the distinguishing features of the bahá'í

252 225-2. See no. 48, pp. 81-85.

253 225-3. muhj, no. 453.8.225.7

225 7a

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227 5faith is the extent to which it liberates the individual to give expression to
 228 his understanding of the bahá'í Teachings and to offer to the institutions

229 of the faith his views about the needs and opportunities which he perceives
230 to exist. however, this remarkable freedom of thought is accompanied by
231 the duty placed upon every believer to obey the Spiritual Assemblies, and to
232 recognize that the wisdom of consultation by an Assembly may be regarded
233 as yielding a greater understanding of an issue than that to which one indi-
234 vidual has access.

235 you are assured of the loving prayers of the house of justice in the holy
236 Shrines on your behalf, that you may achieve your desire for a deeper under-
237 standing of the verities of the faith of bahá'u'lláh, and that your endeavors
238 in the path of service to his cause may be divinely guided and confirmed.

Department of the secretariat

239 226

Message to the Youth Forum, Ontario, Canada

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]